Liquid Healing

By Mark Donnelly

INTRODUCTION

"Seeing is believing" the old song says. But what if you're robbed of sight? Are you then robbed of belief? Belief in life, belief in people, belief in yourself. Can you struggle on? Or are you blind to more than the visual images the world has to offer? "Liquid Healing" by Mark Donnelly

(Tim McCoy, a blind man in his mid 20s, walks on stage. He turns off the light switch on the wall and the lights dim so he is somewhat in shadow. He struggles to find a chair, hits it as he walks, curses, then gropes and finds the chair arm.)

TIM: There. Now we're all in the dark. *(Pause.)* How'd I get like this? A fight, man. gang kids. Fourth of July . . . Bang . . . I was going to pick up Molly, then drive us out to Jones Beach to watch the fireworks with some friends. *(Pause.)* Fireworks, all right. I'm coming out of the liquor store and I see these punks breaking into my car. One of these creeps got a coat hanger and he's shimmying it through the window to get the door button up . . . I had an older car . . . '83 Cutlass. And this jerk's just about got it open. Like a game in a penny arcade where you use the little crane to extract the prize.

There's three of these guys, but I don't care. I snap. I drop my shopping bag I'm so pissed, and the six-pack of Michelob and the soda all smash on the ground. I go after the guy with the hanger and grab his arm. And one of his pals jumps *me*. Then Coat Hanger pokes me in the left eye. I'm screaming and I've got blood allover *me*. The punks just left me there lying on the pavement. The store owner comes out . . . Asian man. I gotta be grateful to

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him. He ripped his sport shirt off and rapped it around my face. Got me down to the emergency room with his son driving like a madman. *(Pause.)*

The doctor couldn't save my eye. And here's the kicker. I end up eventually going blind in the right eye, too, because I'm diabetic. My father died of it when I was twelve. Then the diabetes started working on me at about twenty. Six months or so after the fight, that right eye was acting up . . . my vision got cloudier and cloudier. . . I was in my third year at St. John's. *(Pause.)* By the end of the spring semester I could barely see the print in my textbooks. I was using a magnifying glass, then even that wasn't helping. I walked out of my Business Management final. Couldn't read the charts and graphs. *(Pause.)* That summer the doctor told me my diabetes made the deterioration in the other eye irreversible. I dropped out when that eye went and I was completely blind. *Lights out* for old Tim McCoy . . . only I'm still here walking around . . . just barely . . . Yeah, that trip to the fridge for more beers is a killer . . . *(Pause.)*

You know what I miss? I miss going into the kitchen in the dark late at night and letting the light from the fridge brighten up the room just a little . . . *(As if talking to the inside of the refrigerator)* No more Mr. Bright Guy now, you little light. You still working? Still amazing millions of other drunks with your late night bath of artificial sunshine? *(Pause. Speaks directly to audience again.)* Didn't know I was so sensitive and literary did you? That's what an education can do for you. *(Pause.)* Oh, I tried to go back to college again to finish up. Had a counselor for the handicapped there who tried to help me

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with Braille. But that's tough. I think it's almost easier if you're blind as a kid. He also told me there's some kind of stuff you can do on the computer that's voice activated. Said there's all sorts of support groups for blind people . . . I know all that now. I went to one of those groups. The people even kid around, call themselves Blinks. But I'm not laughing. I felt uncomfortable around them. *(Pause.)*

I'm getting disability checks from the Government. Even had money to pay for readers when I was still taking courses. Molly did some of it, but she'd never take the money. So I also got other readers through her . . . Molly was an elementary education major and some of her classmates were up for that kind of work . . . They didn't know what they were in for with me though. I gave 'em hell, I just was so frustrated and pissed off. I gave up altogether and never finished my degree. *(Pause.)* I'm not doing much now . . . unless you call smoking and drinking doing something. *(Pause.)* My hobby? I watch TV . . . I mean, listen to TV . . . and get loaded. *(Lights a cigarette and smokes it.)*

They tell me all the smoking and drinking is bad for me. My mother is worried I'll fall asleep with a lit cigarette and burn the house down. *(Pause.)* I don't blame her. She works hard all day and comes home to find me in my sweats. Some days I don't even bother to take a shower. *(Pause.)* Where am I? Living in the house I grew up in and blind as a bat. Talk about feeling like the baby brother! *(Pause.)* My sister Susan . . . she's a nurse. She comes by, but she's busy with her little boy. And my brother Bobby, he brings me out

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to his place on Long Island some weekends. It's better in the summer because he has a small motorboat he takes out into the Sound. He likes to get out there, says it clears his head from all the crap he sees as a New York City cop. But do you know how much you miss when you're out there on the water and you're blind? Sure, I can smell the salt, and put my hand in the water, and feel the sun . . . but *I can't see any of it . . .* I gotta rely on my memories of all that stuff . . . and they fade, man . . . really fade. *(Pause.)*

Bobby's got a girlfriend named Marie. And they're gettin' married next year. Where's that put me? Mr. Third Wheel? *(Pause.)* Not this guy. I don't want it. *(Pause.)* I mentioned Molly already. I met her at St. John's before all this happened to me. Beautiful girl . . . Great girl . . . too great . . . stuck by me through all of this . . . Said it didn't matter if I was blind. Said she loved me, man and still wanted to marry me . . . we'd talked about that seriously before the accident . . . accident . . . He should have his own eyes gauged out, man. *(Pause.)*

Sometimes I wake up at night from dreams where I've thrown acid in his face . . . then destroyed him by ripping his arms and legs off. . . Molly said I've got so much rage that's still inside me . . . that's what all the nutso drinking's about. . . I yell and scream at everybody. . . my family, friends. . . and Molly. She tried to calm me. . . tried to get me to talk to a therapist. I went a couple of times, but it didn't change anything. Didn't reduce the rage. Why wouldn't I be in a rage! What am I gonna do, rot in this house the rest of my life? *(Pause.)*

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I'd be at Molly's apartment and I'd be touching her, so soft and smooth . . . and she would hold me close . . . but I couldn't see her. . . I couldn't see her face anymore, and look in her eyes. *(Sadder.)* Never can again. *(Pause.)* I pushed her. . . I pushed her . . . I made things so ugly for her. . . I think it was intentional now. I couldn't bear her leaving me someday. I couldn't believe anybody could love me so much, put up with so much to stay with a blind guy. So I pushed her out the door . . . How else? What else? It's hard man. . . I love her, but I don't want to be pitied. I don't want to be a charity case for her. *(Pause.)*

What kind of job am I gonna get? A vocational counselor told me that with my intelligence and skills there were plenty of opportunities for me. Opportunities?! You know anybody who wants a blind office manager? Blind stock broker? And skills? What skills! *(Pause.)* I never did know what the hell I wanted. Used to dream of flying planes when I was a kid. My grandfather flew in World War II. But when he died, my dream sort of died, too. . . And did you ever hear of a blind pilot? *(Pause.)*

Molly's teaching at an elementary school out in Glen Cove. She's good with kids, she's got patience. . . I'm probably the biggest kid she had to deal with. . . drove me to campus after I got hurt. . . Didn't matter if her classes weren't lined up with mine. She worked around it. . . she went all out for me. . . wouldn't give up on me. . . but I made it too rough for her. . . And now she's gone.

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